THE JUNGLE BOOK

V.J. JAMES'S SLIM NOVEL PARSES COMPLEX ISSUES THROUGH CONTEMPORARY CHARACTERS MODELLED ON THE PANDAVAS FROM THE MAHABHARATA

When I was an undergrad, the then-recent film *Into the Wild* (2007), about a disillusioned young American who retreated into the Alaskan wilderness and eventually both starved and accidentally poisoned himself to death, was all the rage. 'Society', Eddie Vedder's existential anthem from the movie, declared: "*Society, you're a crazy breed/ Hope you're not lonely without me.*" What I disliked about this technically accomplished but curiously soulless movie was its unsubtle, soft-focus romanticisation of voluntary seclusion as well as mental illness. V.J. James's recently published novel-in-translation, *Dattapaharam: Call of the Forest* (translated by Ministhy S.), also investigates a young man's forest retreat, his quest to achieve "unity with nature". But the book does so with such startling insights and depth of characterisation that it leaves unidimensional, wannabe-*Walden* narratives like *Into the Wild* far, far behind.

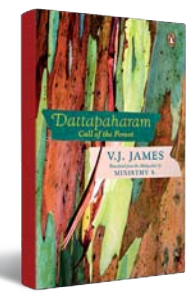
The young man in question, Freddie Robert, is the lynchpin among a group of five engineering college students, all male, who satirically call themselves the 'Pandavas' (naturally, Freddie is Yudhishthira, the eldest and wisest). Later, when a young woman named Meera joins their coterie, she is promptly dubbed 'Panchali' (an alternative name for Draupadi) to complete the in-joke. At the beginning of the novel, we are told that Freddie, who had retreated into the forest months ago, has been spotted in that same forest not far from their college campus.

But when the Pandavas and Meera embark on a trek to find their lost friend, they realise that Freddie's philosophical reasons for exile may be coherent and pragmatic—and contagious. Each of the Pandavas has a different sort of relationship with Freddie but, one by one, they all fall under his spell; in absentia, too.

There's so much happening in this novel that it's often a challenge to keep track of the themes. There's a broad critique of societal mores, there's the duality of the corporeal college campus and the forest with its spiritual heft, there's the Nietzschean, eternal-return aspect of the characters 'following' the fates of their mythological namesakes—at the end of the Mahabharata, the aged Pandavas (and Draupadi/Panchali) embark on a Himalayan nature-pilgrimage, leaving their 'earthly selves' behind.

At the end of the day, though, Freddie himself is the most compelling part of *Dattapaharam*. Inexorably drawn to what he feels is an honest, even sacred way to live, he collapses the boundaries between himself and nature. He's an example of what the cultural theorist Raymond Williams called 'ecosystem people', folks adept at maintaining a harmonious coexistence between themselves and their natural surroundings. But he's so much more—a despot in some ways, a saint in others, a fully-formed, human character who isn't easy to pin down as either hero or anti-hero. "When you open the windows of vision and invite darkness inside, it steps in with infinite love...," says a character at around the 40-page mark. It's a great teaser for what's about to follow in this clever and frequently disconcerting novel. ■

Aditya Mani Jha



DATTAPAHARAM: Call of the Forest
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have been known for their achievements in sports and culture, but Kundra recounts multiple incidents of young entrepreneurs from the northeast fighting all odds to venture onto uncharted paths. The book is not an advertisement of the work of any particular government but showcases how sincere execution of schemes and projects can make a difference.

For the uninitiated, there are some interesting nuggets too. The current BJP dispensation has often made noises about the alleged 'ulterior' motives of Christian missionaries. Kundra narrates how a secret note prepared by T.N. Kaul, Nehru's confidant and joint secretary in the ministry of external affairs, advocated shutting down of foreign missionary activities and suggested establishment of social organisations such as Ramakrishna Mission and Gandhi Sewak Sangh in the northeast.

What handicaps the book is Kundra's evident lack of exposure or disinterest in Assam, the region's biggest state. He sweeps the decades-long strife against illegal immigrants from Bangladesh, the emergence of ULFA and return of peace under vague brushstrokes. He is also factually inaccurate in a few observations. For instance, he invents a new theory that Sylhet becoming part of East Pakistan led to a cultural assertion by the Assamese in Assam. Elsewhere, he talks of sari-clad schoolgirls cycling home. In Assam, schoolgirls wear 'mekhela chador' as uniform, not sari. Kundra displays his awareness of 'mekhela chador' in another chapter, making this inaccuracy surprising. ■

Kaushik Deka